CHAPTER 17

DANIELLA

8 September 2003

ENGLAND vs SOUTH AFRICA, 5th Test, *The Oval*

Series drawn 2-2

We've just beaten South Africa in the final Test of the summer at the Oval. The series has ended 2-2 as the team, now led by Michael Vaughan, has taken their inherited stubbornness, their rugged refusal to be beaten, and are turning it into something more expressive, unburdened and optimistic. Alec Stewart has been paraded off on the shoulders of teammates at the end, his last Test for England played out at his home ground. I will see so many more go over the years. I've taken the most wickets in the series – 15 – and yet it's still hard to understand why any of it goes right and why any of it goes wrong. I'm just doing, hoping, on the crest of a wave at 22 years old.

We are in Elysium Bar in Mayfair after the Oval win. There is a united, collective sense of a Test series just finished, a kind of end-of-school feeling in the air. Most of the squad are here and the evening is cartwheeling over itself in the usual slur of cocktails and pints and the thing I am learning international cricketers love more than anything – not talking about cricket.

My eyes meet hers from across the room. It's dark with red neon lights interrupting the line of sight, but operating in the packs that cricket teams tend to – a code of behaviour not broken by the real-life splintering that other people my age are contending with – we all go over to meet her and her friends. She is called Daniella. When I tell her I play cricket, she says, politely, 'Yes, but what's your real job?' Someone interrupts, telling her that